“You seem to have had a good day,” Léa said.

“I met André.” Rose removed her shoes. “Look what he gave me.” She pulled a box from her bag.

When Léa saw *Pastels Girault* printed on the ribbon, she couldn’t believe André had that kind of money. Hadn’t Rose said he was responsible for his mother and siblings? She felt a pang of worry that he might be engaged in something illegal to afford such a gift. But she didn’t want to say it yet. She had enough bad news to deliver without adding more. “He’s very generous.”

“Yes. He’s invited—”

“Sit down for a moment.” She needed to say it right away so she wouldn’t make the mistake of holding off any longer. “I lost my job.”

Rose sank onto the bed. “But you’re Maître Mallon’s best typist.”

“He’s lost his clients.”

“I don’t understand. You were always there late finishing his files.” Lifting her knees, Rose placed her chin on them, her wide eyes staring at Léa. “He must have had so many clients.”

“He’s an honorable man.” Léa took a breath. “But in France, at the moment, the people who are in power and those who work for the government aren’t honorable at all. They only care about enriching themselves. Even if it makes the country poorer.” Rose stood and came by Léa’s side. “They’ve made an example of him to deter others. I was the last typist he let go. There is literally nothing for me to type.”

A look of despair showed in Rose’s eyes. “I’m so sorry.”

Léa took her sister’s hand. “Unfortunately, I have more bad news. Madame Martin dropped a bombshell today. She’s increasing the rent in October.” Despite her determination to remain strong, her voice cracked. “I’ve saved enough to cover the one hundred and fifty francs for October, but we can’t pay more.” She shook her head. “We won’t be able to stay.” The weight of these words hung in the air. A shadow fell over their future.

“I’ll sell the pastels on the black market—will it be enough?”

Tears pricked Léa’s eyes. “No, I don’t want you to do that.” She twisted her finger around the edge of her sleeve, shame burning inside. She was the one meant to be providing for them.

“You’ve done so much for me,” Rose said. “How much more does she want?”